

The Cypher Indecypherable

“What a distraction, indeed, for the heart & soul is a grammar that is more than 6,000 years old!”

—Jean-François Champollion, 1816 letter to a friend

Though I am not now far from youth, I am far enough perhaps to look back upon the moments which shaped me. From the high banks of the creek when spring was near, I used to watch water flowing swift beneath thinning ice. The past is like that ice—according to the weather it is more or less the waters underneath it, which are time. Except the past grows firmer under rays of recollections warm, & more dissolute under chilly-eyed inspection. I recall with perfect clarity my earliest dreams, but I have never understood them. Next to dreams, my dearest memories are of games. One game in particular is the blood of my heart, for in youth it was the circumference of my hopes. It is a singular game; its nature is cryptographic, & its play very simple: each year, all who are of age propose a solution to the cypher called Eliza’s Riddle. A correct solution earns its author a name immortal & the right to install a new cryptogram in place of Eliza’s, which shall stand until broken by another.

The game is said to have arrived at Oldenbarnevelt with François Adriaan van der Kemp, who may himself have learned it from the Oneida in the vicinity of Nieuw Rotterdam. The patriot first sought a game with Adam Mappa, but the colonel, preferring his accustomed match of chess, bid him show it to the children instead. The young Mappas took up the diversion with zeal, & on returning some weeks later, van der Kemp was surprised to be shown a code he was not then able to crack. Our Dutchman was

several days distracted by this cryptogram, & solving it at last was amazed to see such wit in minds so fresh. Accordingly, he organized a great cryptathlon amongst the youngsters of the village, to take place on the 1st day of spring, 1806. Its prize was a wreath of maple (olive does not grow in Oldenbarnevelt), & every equinox since has been marked by the spectacle of the games.

In the agon's 1st half-century, many cryptographers witnessed the accession & abdication of their cyphers. Through the 1840's, the longest-reigning cryptogram only 3 years wore the crown. But in 1855, a young woman named Eliza, of the Birdsall family who lived on Remsen Road, proposed her eponymous Riddle. When the equinoxial gathering began, she was first to assail the reigning cryptographer. A brief glance at the sheet of paper she tendered was enough to tell her rival of his regency's end—Eliza had lain his labyrinth in a line. The wreath of maple became her crown, the Riddle her sword in the stone. So long were the assailants of this cypher unsuccessful that van der Kemp's rules (sound & farsighted though they were) required amendment. For with each year the crypt remained sealed, Eliza drew nearer her own. At length it was decided that the Riddle would pass to a youth of Eliza's choosing, who would renounce the game for life to guard the cypher. In 1897 the secret changed hands, & 3 times since it has passed to a successor. Eliza's Riddle has remained officially unsolved for 168 years.

* * *

By my own day, the Cryptathlon was no longer held in the village of Oldenbarnevelt. Attempts upon Eliza's Riddle were presented instead at the local high school, which is situated in a neighboring village of name unknown to fame. There the Cryptathlon had been relegated to the status of a minor ritual, performed each year by students of the senior class. By such

departures from tradition, the game had become for most a fixed & mundane part of it—yet for others it was something more.

I have said that the game was singular. Perhaps its history & its rules are not so strange as the way in which a handful of students from each class—not invariably the best or the worst—seemed to devote themselves entirely to its mysteries, as though the sum & substance of their education were to solve Eliza's Riddle. It will not shock the reader to learn I was part of this set. The serious players in my class were few; in retrospect, none were so intolerably serious as I. From middle school I bent my studies to the delicate science of cryptography, writing & decrypting cyphers of every type described in the books of the library. By sophomore year I worked on the Riddle to the exclusion of all else. By senior I was utterly dismayed. For in all those years I had gotten precisely nowhere in my quest for an answer, while the fated end of my labors drew mercilessly nearer.

As snows of December turned to torrents of mid-March, I sat in the library staring blankly at the *Astronomica*. The chair across from me stirred & our valedictorian-to-be sat down. She glanced from the book to my fallen countenance & laughed. "Still haven't solved it," she observed. I answered her that I hadn't, & that I feared I never would.

"My sole consolation," I said, "is that no one else will solve it either." At that she was mischievously silent. "What?" I asked, & again when she shook her head. Not until she'd glugged with my pleas did she tell me what I dreaded to hear.

"The Riddle has been solved," she said slowly, "now, & in the past."

"That is impossible," I protested, but her smile only broadened. "Who has solved it?"

"Eliza had successors," came the reply. "How do you think they were chosen?"

I shook my head. "Then what is the solution?" She looked at me without speaking, & suddenly a greater horror set upon me.

"You said it had been solved now..." She nodded slowly, sitting back in her chair. Understanding, I was silent. After some minutes, I awakened once more from my dejection. "Please," I said, motioning to the open book before me & the others spread out on the table, "I have to know."

Her smile returned & she shook her head; the chair stirred again as she rose to leave. I thought she had already gone when I heard her voice from behind me: "Eliza told riddles, but never lies."

As the Cryptathlon approached, I could not bear to think of the Riddle. Naturally I thought of nothing else. I redoubled my efforts, sans the excitement with which they had begun, sans the determination which long had given them color. I now approached the Riddle with a despondency & a question—the despondency growing with every failed attempt, the question always the same: why, if the Riddle had an answer, had it not been vouchsafed to me? My devotion to its mysteries was surely sufficient, or at least more constant than that of my classmates. And I could hardly believe that the offerings of the past had pleased any more than my own—after all I knew them, understood them, had built on what progress they made. Why then was I shut so coldly out of knowing, why passed over by fate? *Eliza, Eliza, lama sabachthani?*

The vernal judgment day was soon upon me. The assembly was called, & all who sought Eliza's crown of maple formed a line, their paper hopes held close to heaving hearts. By the shortness of the queue & my once-great ardor to lead it, my absence was made readily apparent; my friends & teachers importuned me to try, but sullenly I waved them all away. No delays permitted by the Riddle's esteemed Keeper, the rolls were closed & the ceremony commenced. I watched from my seat the first aspirant climb the steps at the right of the stage. He placed before the Keeper his page-dense labor of years & paused to await its assessment. The Keeper's pen scratched a moment in a

clothbound book, then returned to silence. A meaning glance was raised, & the nonelect cryptographer descended once more on the left. So rose & so fell the next, & on went the solemn procession.

Before long our valedictorian was ascending. My heart stopped my throat as she sauntered centerstage—I hardly noticed the emptiness of her hands. She paused before the Keeper & spoke, & her words were a whisper unaccountably clear: “I make no submission.” The pen spoke once more, & our valedictorian returned like the others to her seat.

* * *

I will not long dilate on the confusion which that day silenced me, nor on the rage which closely followed. I seethed at being tricked, at being cheated of my chance to solve the Riddle. Why had she bothered to deceive me, if she meant to make no attempt herself? And why climb the steps to tell the Keeper so? In alternating bouts of fury & obsequiousness I assailed her for answers, yet she, silent, offered no explanation. I felt as forsaken by her as by Eliza.

With summer came the end of high school & the divergence of our paths. And though years have intervened, neither she nor Eliza has long been truant from my thoughts. I return often to the cypher-strewn notebooks of my youth—on a thousand nights & a night I have convinced myself that Eliza’s Riddle has no answer. But in euphoric moments of seeing beyond sight a mania shakes me, repeating *The Riddle has been solved*. It is not until a corresponding depression sets in that I am reminded of our valedictorian’s last assertion: both these things may be true. *Eliza told riddles, but never lies*. Thus by turns am I buoyed & drowned by the symbols of the past.

This spring I was dealt wounds yet fresh, for I have learned through the Cryptathlon’s newsletter (to which I am reluctantly & inevitably subscribed) that the former Keeper of the

Riddle, who served the duration of my days & longer, has relinquished that high office. A successor has been chosen—though I fear I need not tell you, dear reader, who she is, nor what anguish the choice has caused me. The newsletter states (contrary to fact) that “the 5th Keeper of the Riddle made her submission during the 208th Cryptathlon, held in 2014.” It also contains an interview with our newly appointed Keeper, wherein she recounts her memories of the game. I was relieved, if somewhat surprised, not to find myself among them. Curious, too, were the words of advice she offered to those on the eve of competing: “Play. And remember the words of Eliza.”

Those words, of course, are those Eliza delivered at the Cryptathlon of 1855:

“It is well known that Mr. van der Kemp, from the radiations of his illumined mind, gave life to the game we are gathered here to play. Its first winners were children, & a child has won it this day. For though I am older now than the Mappas of the game’s beginning, I find that whenever I play, I am as a child once again. To play is the soul’s rejuvenation, & in this ever-youthful spirit do I, who have solved a riddle today, put before you a riddle of years.

“It is written: ‘Except ye be converted, & become as little children, ye shall not enter into the kingdom of heaven.’ Neither shall ye solve this riddle, for it will yield no secret to the sciences of men. In cyphers only cyphers shall you find; but only seek to play, & our game shall live forever.”

Her inaugural address recited, Eliza turned over the page, placed it on the lectern, & receded as the crowd came to look. On the back was scrawled the cypher at which so many have wondered.

I myself have wondered if I should not at last resign to the advice of the great cryptographer. Perhaps it is time I abandon my cryptanalytic endeavors. Though my method has been honed

from the days of my adolescence, I do perceive the madness in't. Yet not madness only & torture have I found in the Riddle, but *play*. Yes, every vain idea still sets my mind on fire, each rounding of a corner in the maze—though it bring once more the old unchanging walls—awakes in me the thrill of seeing the light. Does not the game have life in this as well? I shall press on in memory of time lost & yet to lose, for how to play & not to seek solutions I have not the rope to fathom.